

Hotline to HOPE

The two Asian powers take new initiatives to shed mistrust and realise that there is more to their relationship than the border dispute



S.M. KRISHNA WITH HIS CHINESE COUNTERPART YANG JIECHI

By Saurabh Shukla in Beijing

He who has not climbed the Great Wall is not a true man," said Mao. On the 60th anniversary of their diplomatic ties, India and China were still struggling to scale the old wall of mutual mistrust in an effort to find a common ground of regional cooperation. As the foreign ministers of two Asian powers, India's S.M. Krishna and his Chinese counterpart Yang Jiechi, sat down to sign an agreement

to begin a hotline between the prime ministers of the two countries on April 7, it was indeed a giant leap forward in confidence-building.

With India reaching out to the Chinese leadership, the message was that New Delhi and Beijing should relive the heady days of the late 1980s when the Sino-Indian relationship was at its best following Rajiv Gandhi's visit to China in 1988. Recalling his meetings with Manmohan Singh and Sonia Gandhi, Chinese Premier Wen Jiabao told Krishna when the two met, "There

is a Chinese saying that at 30 an individual finds his identity, at 40 there is no doubt about the course and at 50 one realises that one is at a heavenly state. Only at 60 does one find the way to move forward, and this is what the two countries have found now."

His words matched the mood. Even on the vexed border dispute, the Chinese leadership has signalled some positive movement. "Talks are on and we hope for an early and proper settlement. We must do our utmost to promote friendship and relationship in